

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Semi-Slav Defense for White

Meran, Anti-Meran, Moscow, Anti-Moscow, and the critical central breaks

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

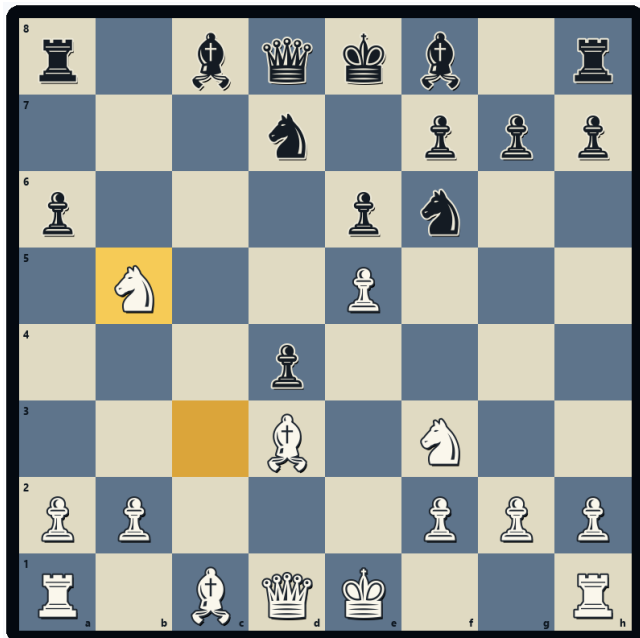
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE	20

01. Meran Main Line



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the development lead to gain central space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

01. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.
PIECE JOB	White's bishops and central pawns become powerful only if the king is ready for the center to open.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.
TRADE FILTER	Keep attacking pieces while the center is open, but trade a defender when that makes the e5 advance or kingside attack concrete.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central expansion to open lines, then shift from pawn play to piece play before Black consolidates. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.

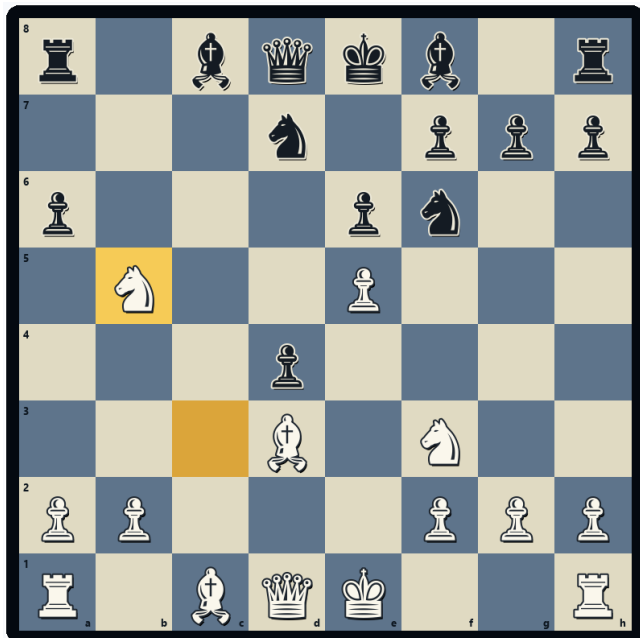
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

02. Meran Main Line



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the development lead to gain central space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

02. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.
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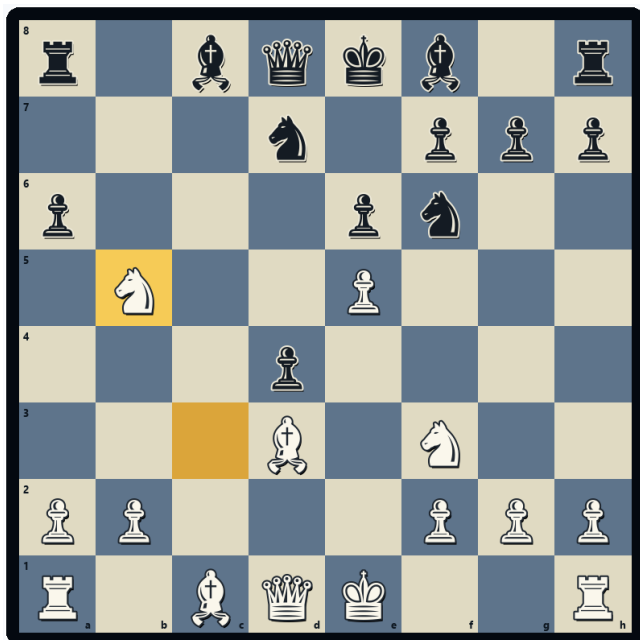
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03. Meran Main Line



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the development lead to gain central space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

REFERENCE LINE

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MEMORY RULE

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03. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line

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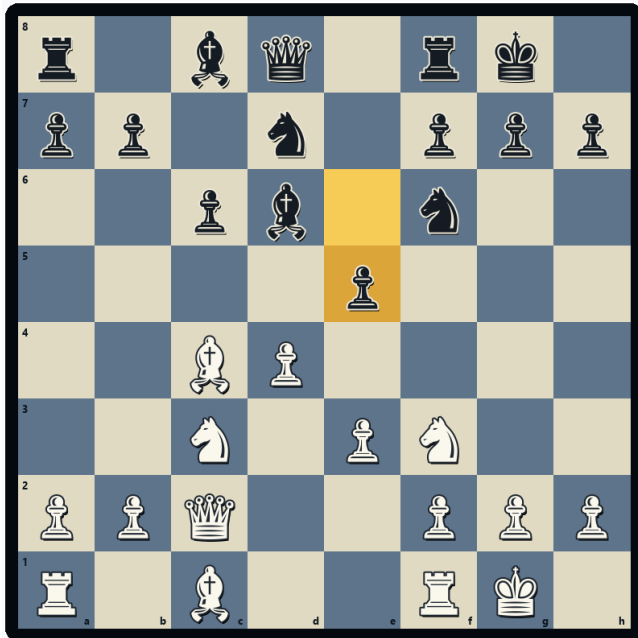
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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04. Anti-Meran with Qc2



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Qc2, Bd3, and O-O to support central expansion.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bd6: Black develops toward h2 and prepares castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

04. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.
PIECE JOB	Qc2 supports e4 and keeps the bishop flexible, but White must finish development before treating the queen move as an attack.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.
TRADE FILTER	Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, coordinate rooks and use the queen's support of e4 to claim the center at the right moment. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.

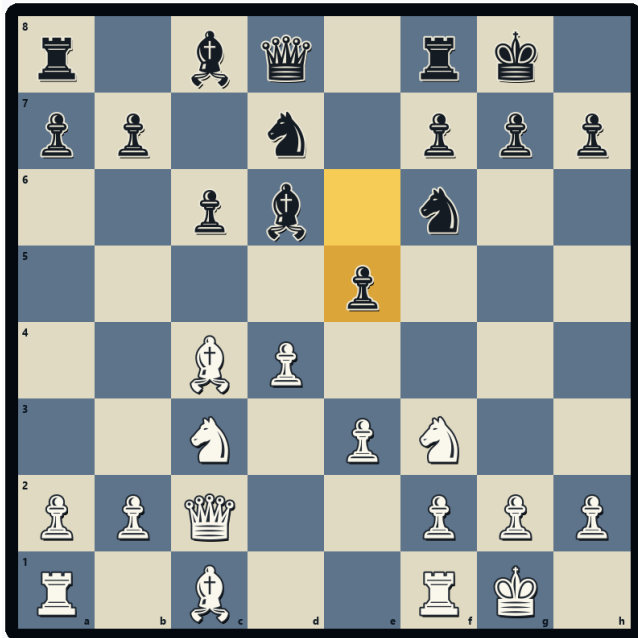
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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05. Anti-Meran with Qc2



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PRIMARY PLAN

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OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

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REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

05. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2

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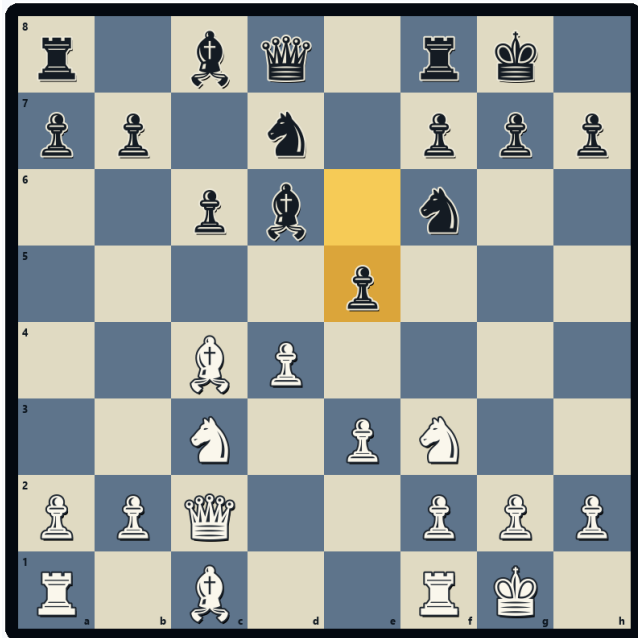
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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06. Anti-Meran with Qc2



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

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PRIMARY PLAN

Use Qc2, Bd3, and O-O to support central expansion.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bd6: Black develops toward h2 and prepares castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

06. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.
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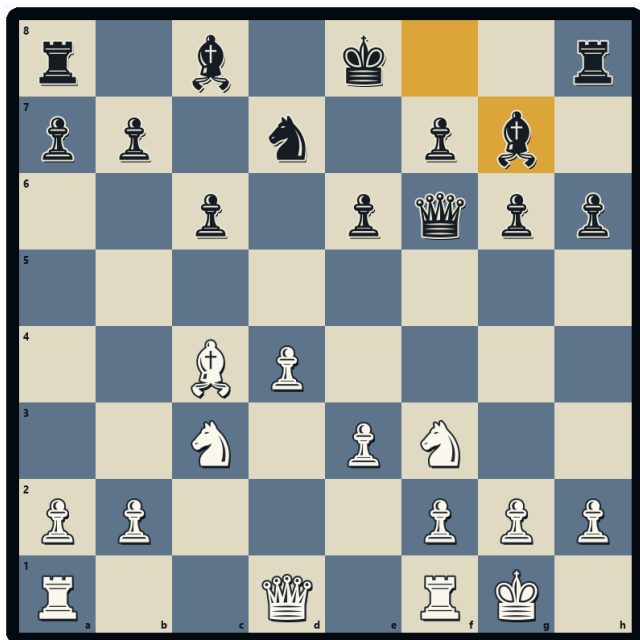
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07. Moscow Variation



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd3, O-O, and Ne4 against the exposed queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qxf6: Black keeps a sound structure and the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

07. Decision Framework

Moscow Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.
PIECE JOB	Bxf6 reduces Black's kingside activity, but White must use the time to complete development and challenge the center.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.
TRADE FILTER	Trading the g5-bishop for the f6-knight is justified by reduced counterplay and tempo, not by a universal bishop-for-knight rule.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Develop Bd3, castle and use the calmer position to apply pressure before Black's bishops become fully active. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
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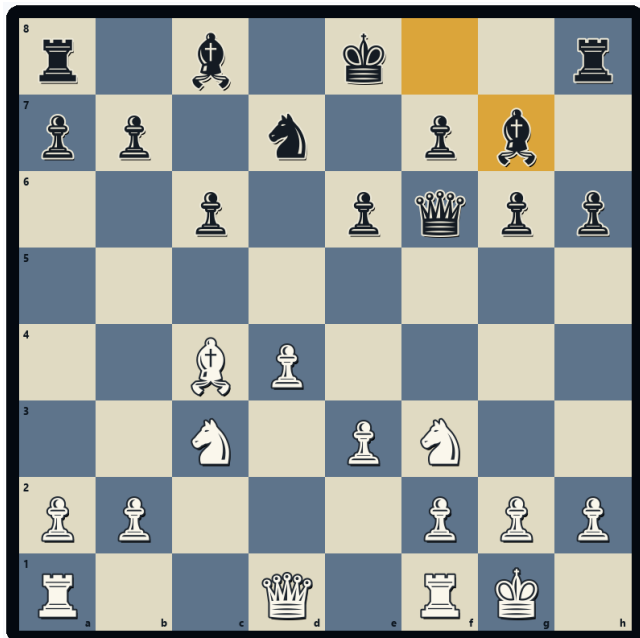
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

08. Moscow Variation



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

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PRIMARY PLAN

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OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

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REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

08. Decision Framework

Moscow Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.
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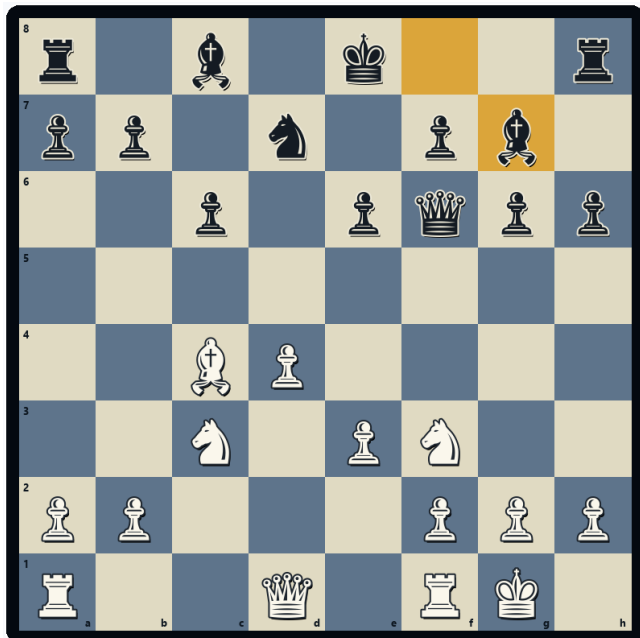
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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09. Moscow Variation



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

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PRIMARY PLAN

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OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

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MEMORY RULE

Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

09. Decision Framework

Moscow Variation

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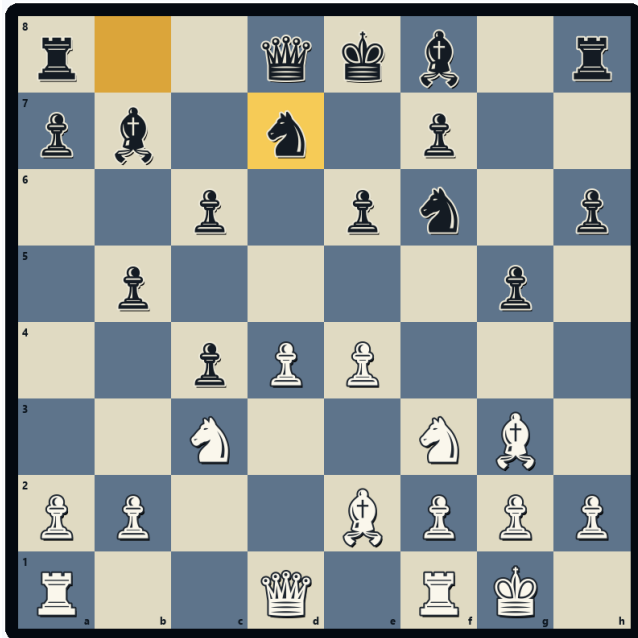
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

10. Anti-Moscow Gambit



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Be2, O-O, and Qc2 before recovering material.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...g5: Black gains the bishop pair and kingside space at structural cost.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Anti-Moscow: preserve the bishop, build e4, castle, then use Black's loosened king.

10. Decision Framework

Anti-Moscow Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.
PIECE JOB	White's center and active bishops compensate for the pawn only if development remains faster than Black's consolidation.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend tempi chasing c4 while Black's king is vulnerable.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid exchanging attacking pieces unless the trade wins back material or leaves a lasting structural gain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, activate rooks and convert the development lead into open lines before attempting to recover every pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
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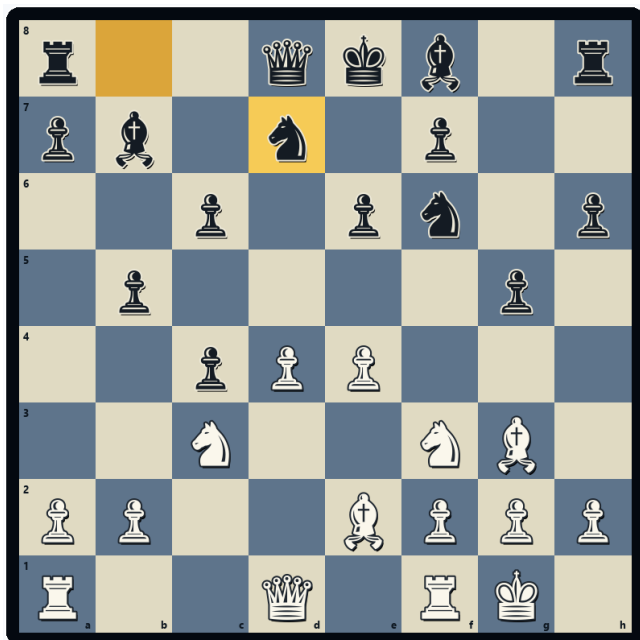
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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11. Anti-Moscow Gambit



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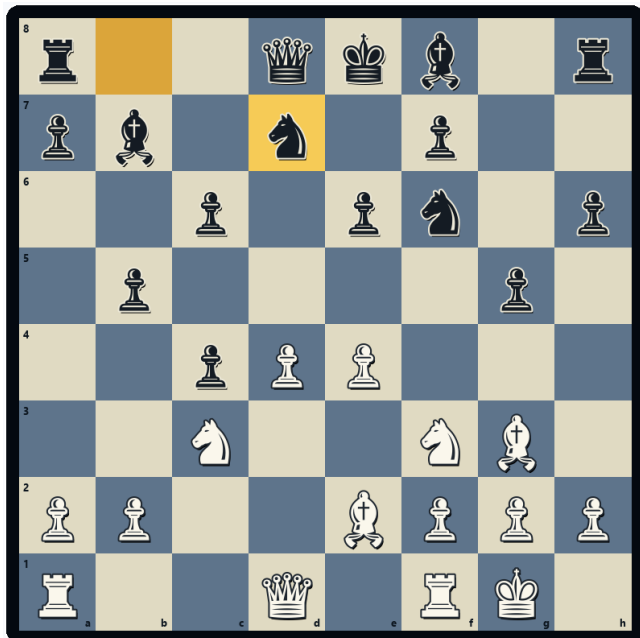
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12. Anti-Moscow Gambit



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

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PRIMARY PLAN

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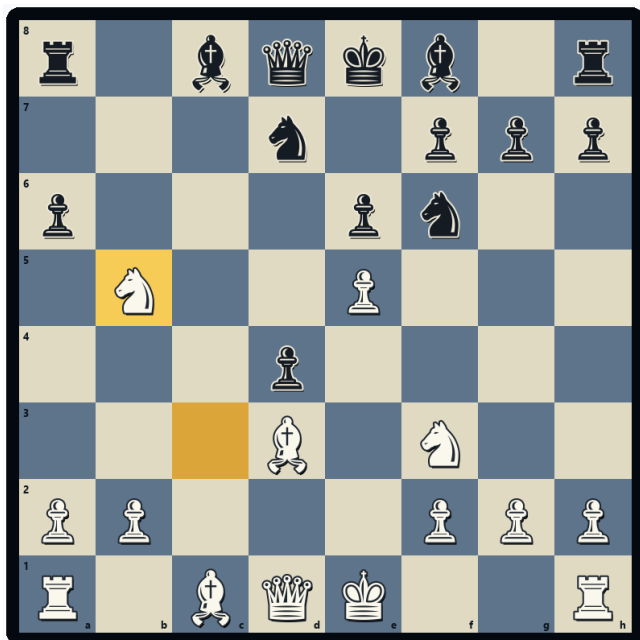
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Anti-Moscow: preserve the bishop, build e4, castle, then use Black's loosened king.

13. Meran Main Line - Move-Order Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

13. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.
PIECE JOB	White's bishops and central pawns become powerful only if the king is ready for the center to open.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.
TRADE FILTER	Keep attacking pieces while the center is open, but trade a defender when that makes the e5 advance or kingside attack concrete.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central expansion to open lines, then shift from pawn play to piece play before Black consolidates. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.

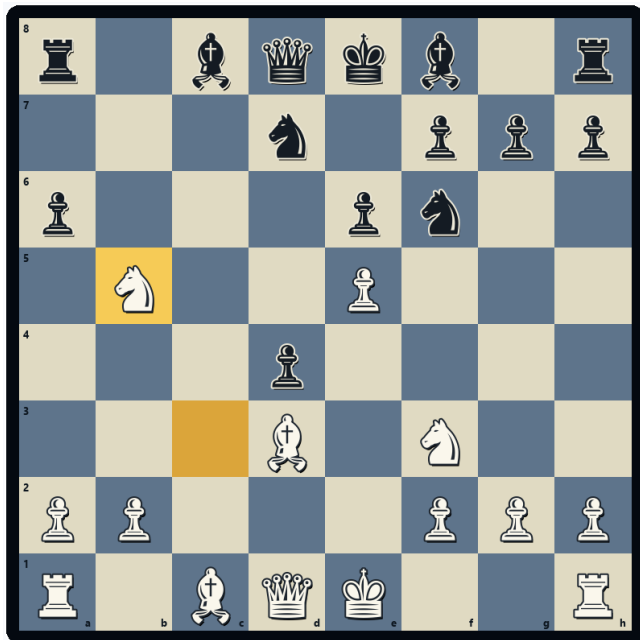
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

14. Meran Main Line - Plan Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

Use the development lead to gain central space.

PRIMARY PLAN

White's bishops and central pawns become powerful only if the king is ready for the center to open.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

14. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.
PIECE JOB	White's bishops and central pawns become powerful only if the king is ready for the center to open.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.
TRADE FILTER	Keep attacking pieces while the center is open, but trade a defender when that makes the e5 advance or kingside attack concrete.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central expansion to open lines, then shift from pawn play to piece play before Black consolidates. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.

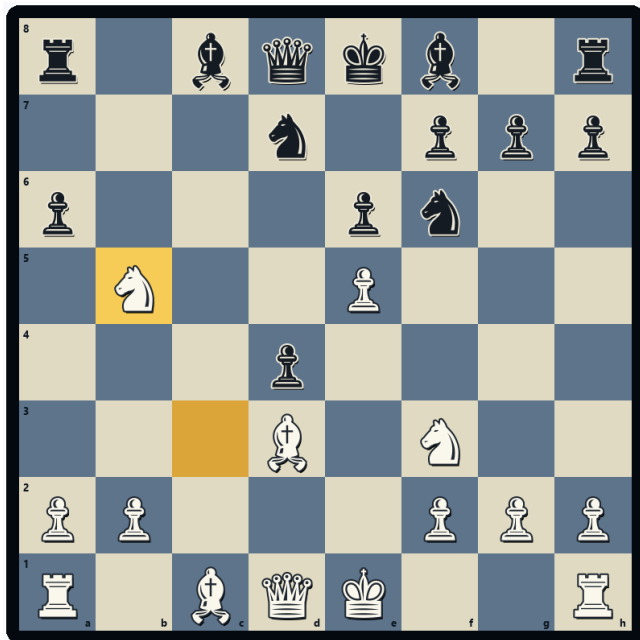
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

15. Meran Main Line - Break Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

15. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.
PIECE JOB	White's bishops and central pawns become powerful only if the king is ready for the center to open.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.
TRADE FILTER	Keep attacking pieces while the center is open, but trade a defender when that makes the e5 advance or kingside attack concrete.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central expansion to open lines, then shift from pawn play to piece play before Black consolidates. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.

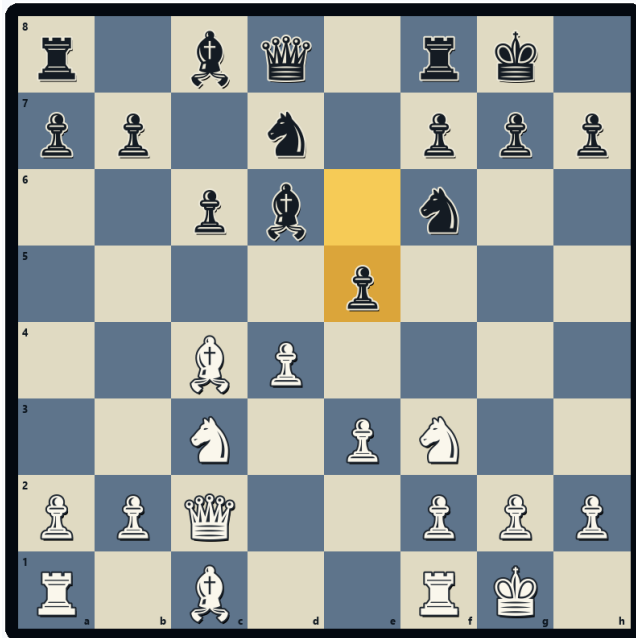
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

16. Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Trade Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.

PRIMARY PLAN

Castle, coordinate rooks and use the queen's support of e4 to claim the center at the right moment. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bd6: Black develops toward h2 and prepares castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

16. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.
PIECE JOB	Qc2 supports e4 and keeps the bishop flexible, but White must finish development before treating the queen move as an attack.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.
TRADE FILTER	Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, coordinate rooks and use the queen's support of e4 to claim the center at the right moment. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.

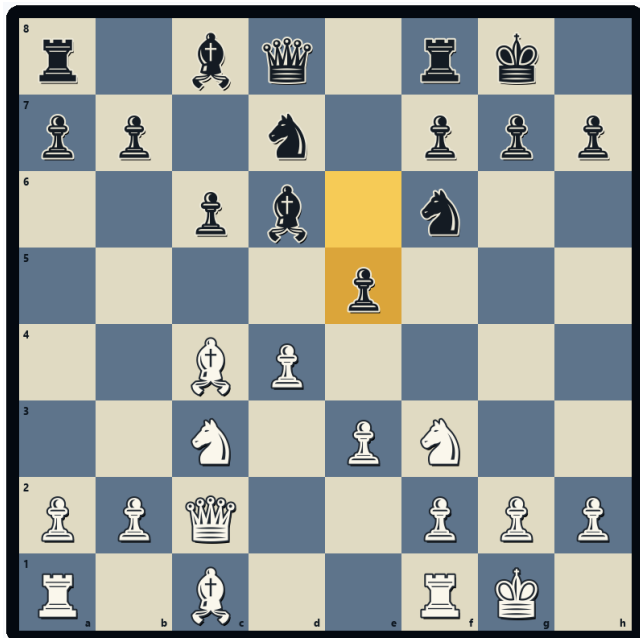
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

17. Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Move-Order Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.

PRIMARY PLAN

Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bd6: Black develops toward h2 and prepares castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

17. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.
PIECE JOB	Qc2 supports e4 and keeps the bishop flexible, but White must finish development before treating the queen move as an attack.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.
TRADE FILTER	Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, coordinate rooks and use the queen's support of e4 to claim the center at the right moment. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.

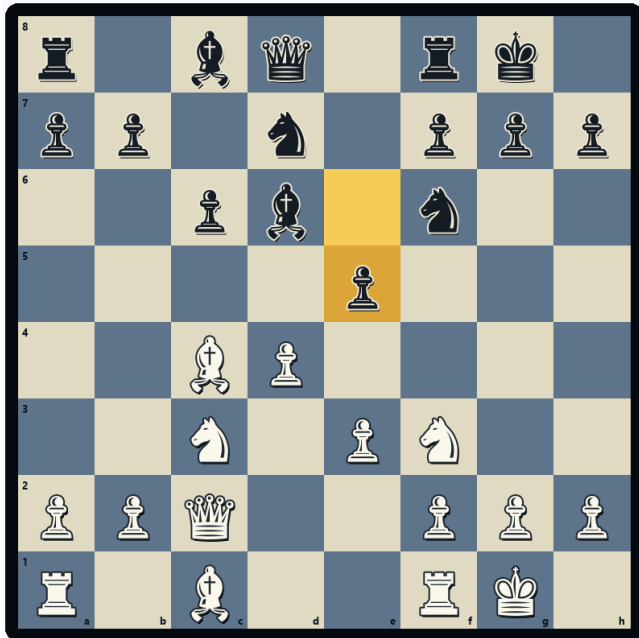
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

18. Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Plan Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

Use Qc2, Bd3, and O-O to support central expansion.

PRIMARY PLAN

Qc2 supports e4 and keeps the bishop flexible, but White must finish development before treating the queen move as an attack.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bd6: Black develops toward h2 and prepares castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

18. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2 - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.
PIECE JOB	Qc2 supports e4 and keeps the bishop flexible, but White must finish development before treating the queen move as an attack.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.
TRADE FILTER	Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, coordinate rooks and use the queen's support of e4 to claim the center at the right moment. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.

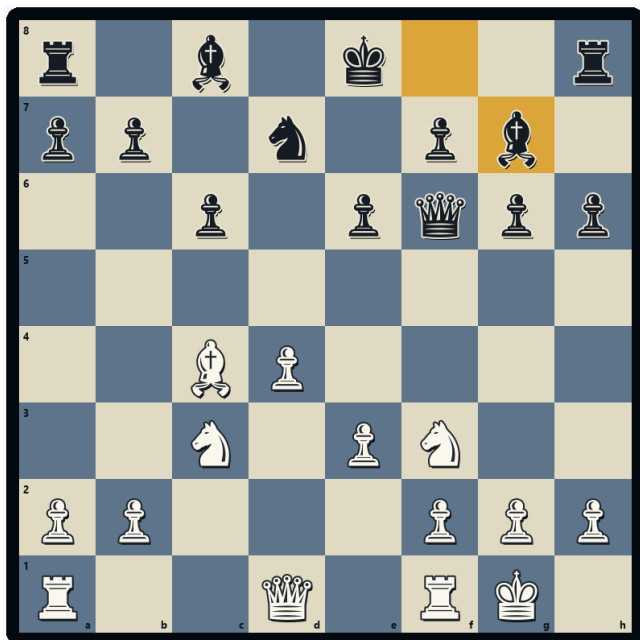
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

19. Moscow Variation - Break Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qxf6: Black keeps a sound structure and the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

19. Decision Framework

Moscow Variation - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.
PIECE JOB	Bxf6 reduces Black's kingside activity, but White must use the time to complete development and challenge the center.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.
TRADE FILTER	Trading the g5-bishop for the f6-knight is justified by reduced counterplay and tempo, not by a universal bishop-for-knight rule.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Develop Bd3, castle and use the calmer position to apply pressure before Black's bishops become fully active. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.

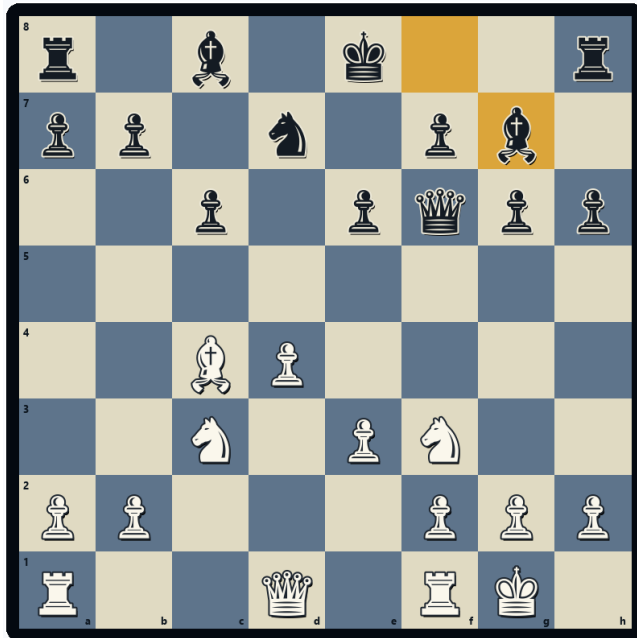
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

20. Moscow Variation - Trade Lab



SEMI-SLAV DEFENSE

READ THE POSITION

Trading the g5-bishop for the f6-knight is justified by reduced counterplay and tempo, not by a universal bishop-for-knight rule.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop Bd3, castle and use the calmer position to apply pressure before Black's bishops become fully active. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qxf6: Black keeps a sound structure and the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

20. Decision Framework

Moscow Variation - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.
PIECE JOB	Bxf6 reduces Black's kingside activity, but White must use the time to complete development and challenge the center.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.
TRADE FILTER	Trading the g5-bishop for the f6-knight is justified by reduced counterplay and tempo, not by a universal bishop-for-knight rule.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Develop Bd3, castle and use the calmer position to apply pressure before Black's bishops become fully active. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.